

Yuchen Zhu

Department of Economics, University of Florida
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EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics , University of Florida	2022 – 2027 (expected)
M.A. in Economics , University of Florida	2024
M.S. in Applied Economics , Johns Hopkins University	2019
B.A. in Economics , minor in Statistics, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	2017

FIELDS

Labor Economics, Econometrics, Applied Microeconomics

JOB MARKET PAPER

Predicting College Major Switching with Machine Learning

Students in U.S. colleges can change their majors as they learn about their academic strengths and fit with different fields, but adjusting late is costly. Using administrative data, I examine what types of information predict major switching. Information available before college predicts switching only weakly. Prediction improves once students enroll and their records accumulate. Performance in a major's core courses is key, predicting even switching that occurs several terms after the courses are taken. Routinely collected academic records can therefore identify switching risk well before the switch takes place, leaving time for advising to respond. At the same advising capacity in each term, a machine learning model identifies 18 percent more next-term switchers than the university's current advising system.

WORKING PAPERS

The Migration Response to Targeted K–12 Funding [\[Draft\]](#)

The Effects on Academic Outcomes of Performance Requirements for Staying in College Majors

(with Robert Ainsworth, Thomas Knight, and Macy McClaren)

WORK IN PROGRESS

Mass Layoffs and Fertility: Evidence from WARN-Based Shocks (with Qilin Zhang)

Quantifying Quality Growth in China: 1988–2009 (with Qilin Zhang)

Effect of Retirement Delay on Labor Market Supply (with Qilin Zhang and Qiushi Hua)

PRESENTATIONS

Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting	2025
Workshop in Applied and Theoretical Economics (WATE), University of Florida	2025
University of Florida Public Economics Group	2025

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record, University of Florida

ECO 4421 Econometrics (Undergraduate)

Spring 2026, Fall 2026

Spring 2026 evaluations (1–5 scale): overall course rating 4.47 (dept. mean 4.30); improved critical thinking 4.58 (dept. mean 4.32)

Teaching Assistant, University of Florida

ECO 4422 Econometrics 2 (Undergraduate)	Fall 2025
ECO 5426 Econometric Analysis 1 (Graduate)	Fall 2025
ECO 4104 Economics of Competitive Strategy (Undergraduate)	Spring 2025
ECO 5427 Econometric Analysis 2 (Graduate)	Spring 2025
ECP 6035 Cost-Benefit Analysis (Master's)	Spring 2024
ECO 3101 Intermediate Microeconomics (Undergraduate)	Fall 2023
ECO 4504 Public Economics (Undergraduate)	Fall 2022

Teaching Assistant, Johns Hopkins University

Real Estate Entrepreneurship (Master's)	2018 – 2019
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RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant to Robert Ainsworth, University of Florida	Spring 2024 – Fall 2024
Research Assistant to David Sappington, University of Florida	Spring 2023 – Summer 2024
Research Assistant to Javier Donna, University of Florida	Spring 2023

OTHER EXPERIENCE

Student Affairs Officer , Zhejiang University, China	2020 – 2022
Managed international student services, the campus career service center, and the campus mental health center; Director of the International Student Council and the Residential College Student Committee (2021 – 2022)	

SKILLS

Software: Python, Stata, R, SQL, SPSS **Certification:** CFA Level I

Languages: English (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (native)

REFERENCES

Robert Ainsworth (Chair) Department of Economics University of Florida robert.ainsworth@ufl.edu	David Sappington Department of Economics University of Florida sapping@ufl.edu	Cecilia Peluffo Department of Economics University of Florida mpeluffo@ufl.edu
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